INITIAL 1-PAGE CONCEPT & LEVEL PITCH DOCUMENT

Still Life (Working Title)

CTIN 534 · Project 3: The Dreamer (World as Enigma) · Initial 4-Room Prototype Pitch

Author / Role	Kevin (Lefi) Shan: Solo Game & Level Designer, Programmer	**Initial Scope**	4 Rooms (10 to 15 minutes playtime · Solo Production)
Engine / Input	Unity (3D URP) / First-Person WASD + Mouse + Interact (E)	**Tone & References**	Deadpan Surrealism (Superliminal, Portal, Rene Magritte)

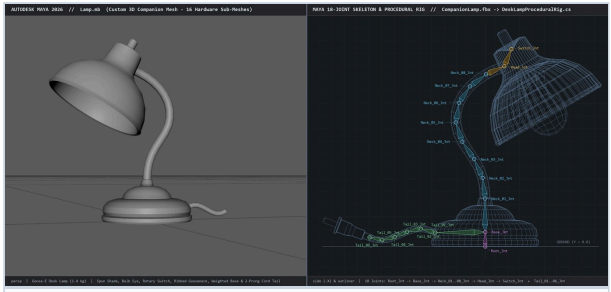
1. HIGH CONCEPT & CORE RULE

Selective Empathy & Behavioral Role Inversion

Humans apply empathy and morality selectively. People naturally care about things that act responsive, vulnerable, or cute, while treating unresponsive creatures as mere resources.

The game takes place in a surreal environment governed by one rule: **inanimate objects act like living creatures, and animals act like inanimate tools.**

The player solves room-to-room spatial puzzles by picking up motionless animals (horses, deer, sheep, dogs) and using them as bridges, counterweights, and gear wedges. Meanwhile, household appliances behave like skittish wildlife. Over the course of the game, the player bonds with a recurring Desk Lamp companion, conditioning the player to treat animals as hardware to protect a household object before the final room subverts this habit.



Custom Maya 3D Model & 18-Joint Rig (Lamp.mb): 16 hardware sub-meshes and 18 joints (Root, Base, Neck 01..08, Head, Switch, Tail 01..06) driven procedurally in C#.

2. CORE MECHANICS & SYSTEMS

Situated Role: The Dreamer (L.O.P. Loop)

System / Pillar	Behavior & Prototype Implementation
Animal-Tools	Animals have no animations, sounds, or AI. Looking at an animal displays a utility prompt (e.g., `[E] Pick up Horse`). When picked up, the animal snaps into the bottom-right viewmodel slot like a standard FPS tool and can be dropped, placed on switches, or laid across gaps.
Living Objects	Household objects (Desk Lamp, Frying Pan, Toaster) use state-driven AI. They flee when approached quickly, shiver in dark or cold zones, and follow the player once comforted.
Desk Lamp Companion	Bonds with the player in Room 1 and follows them through the game. Functions as the primary dynamic light source, shifting color temperature and intensity based on its state.
L.O.P. Loop Alignment	**Legibility:** Mundane prompts set expectations that break when objects flee and animals act as static props. **Opportunity:** The player sees how an animal's collider or weight can control an object's path or safety. **Performance:** The player places animals to corner, bridge, or shield the Desk Lamp to progress.

3. INITIAL LEVEL BREAKDOWN (4-ROOM PITCH STRUCTURE)

Later Expanded into the Final 5-Room / 235 kg Facility

Room 1 (Level 0): Rule Onboarding

`Prompt: "Turn on the light."`

- **Layout:** A dim room with a single spotlight, a Desk Lamp on a table, a motionless Horse, and a dark exit passage.
- **Gameplay:** Approaching the Desk Lamp causes it to click frantically, hop off the table, and flee along the perimeter walls. Approaching the Horse displays `[E] Pick up Horse`, snapping the full-sized horse to the player's right hand.
- **Resolution:** The player places the Horse in a corner to block the Lamp's path. Approaching the cornered, shivering Lamp shows `[E] Comfort Lamp`, shifting its bulb to a warm amber glow so it lights the dark passage into Room 2.

Room 2: Ecosystem & Utility

`Prompt: "Cross the gap."`

- **Layout:** A split room separated by a floor pit and gated by a heavy floor switch.
- **Gameplay:** The Desk Lamp follows the player but stops and whimpers at the pit edge. Secondary objects act as background wildlife: a Frying Pan darts behind a stove like a mouse, and a Toaster shivers in a dark alcove until warmed by the Lamp.
- **Resolution:** The player places a Sheep on the floor switch (`[E] Place Sheep - 25 kg`) and lays a Deer across the pit (`[E] Lay Deer as Bridge`) so the Desk Lamp can hop across on the deer's back.

Room 3: Attachment & Hazard

`Prompt: "Keep it warm."`

- **Layout:** A cold industrial corridor with moving mechanical crushers and freezing air vents.
- **Gameplay:** Cold air causes the Desk Lamp to dim and huddle against the player's leg, refusing to cross the freezing stream.
- **Resolution:** The player uses motionless animals (Dogs, Horses) to jam crusher gears and block freezing vents, leaving animals wedged inside machinery to keep the Lamp warm on the way to the exit.

Room 4: The Subversion

`Prompt: "Leave."`

- **Layout:** A white room with the final exit door and a Disposal Chute wired to the lock: `INSERT 1 INANIMATE OBJECT TO OPEN EXIT`.
- **Gameplay:** Only the bonded Desk Lamp and a motionless Dog are present. Conditioned to treat animals as disposable props, the player drops the Dog into the chute, triggering an alarm: `ERROR: BIOLOGICAL ORGANISM DETECTED`.
- **Resolution:** The sensor rejects the dream rule. To open the exit, the player must drop the shivering Desk Lamp into the chute. When crushed, it makes only the sound of broken plastic and metal, and the exit opens.

4. AESTHETICS & SOLO PRODUCTION SCOPE

Scoping Around Rigging & Animation Bottlenecks

Lighting & Color Theory

Driven by the Desk Lamp: fear states use cold slate-blue shadows and narrow flickering spotlights; bonded states cast warm amber light; the finale snaps to stark white.

Sound Design Contrast

Total silence from motionless animals (only dull thuds when placed) contrasted with expressive mechanical Foley from appliances (springy hops, hums, switch clicks, rattling metal).

Unity Solo Production Scope

Eliminates 3D character rigging/animation bottlenecks: animals use static meshes with Rigidbody/BoxCollider components, while appliances use procedural C# sine-wave hopping and LookAt tilts.